

CHAPTER 18

MEDIA TRIAL

'Mariam, a tuna in bed.'

The Viyyur prison was not bad. Rather, some of the people who manned the prison made it a tolerable place. There was jailor Gopalakrishnan, a friendly middle-aged man, Balakrishnan, the assistant jailor and Sivanandan, a warden.

While all these men were kind to me, Sivanandan developed a special liking for me, often consoling me and trying to cheer me up. He would update me on what newspapers have been reporting on the ISRO spy case. But this warden's second hand reporting left me only gasping for specifics. I asked him for newspapers, even if they come to me a day or two late.

It was only when Sivanandan brought a couple of newspapers that I realised that I haven't told him that I could read only English, not Malayalam. I wanted English papers. The jail did not have English papers, but Sivanandan said he would try his best, through 'proper channels'.

A couple of days later, when he brought a copy of *The New Indian Express*, there were two rectangles cut out of the paper. Sivanandan told me that the superiors had agreed to give me a copy of an English paper, but only after cutting out those stories about the ISRO spy case.

'This doesn't serve my purpose,' I complained.

'Be patient for a few days,' said Sivanandan.

After a few days newspapers started reaching me without the cuts. The stories I read were shocking because of the seriousness the case had attained by then, but those I heard about reporting by Malayalam dailies were unimaginably